

PREMIUM

Refusal Decision Guide

Why there's no appeal, and what actually changes the outcome

Understand your options after a refusal

Outcome	What it means	What you can do
214(b) refusal	The consular officer wasn't convinced of your nonimmigrant intent, study plan, or funding - a discretionary finding, not a fixed checklist failure.	No formal appeal - reapply with a stronger, clearer case.
Administrative processing	Your case needs further review before a final decision - not the same as a refusal.	Generally just requires waiting; contact the consulate only if it significantly exceeds normal timelines.
Reapplication	A new application, assessed fresh, with a new interview.	The only practical path after a 214(b) refusal - address the specific gap directly.

Talk to your DSO if your term start is close

If you're refused or delayed close to your program's start date, contact your school's Designated School Official promptly - they can often defer your I-20's program start date to the next intake, keeping your SEVIS record active rather than requiring a completely fresh admission and I-20 process.

What actually helps on reapplication

- Address the specific concern from your refusal directly and specifically, not with a generally stronger file
- If funding was unclear, prepare a clear, traceable explanation matching your I-20's figure exactly
- If your study plan seemed weak, be ready to explain your program choice and post-graduation plans specifically and consistently

What not to do

- Don't reapply immediately with an unchanged application
- Don't give inconsistent answers between your DS-160, your I-20, and your interview
- Don't submit materially false information to work around a previous refusal

When to seek professional advice

Consider consulting an immigration attorney if you've been refused multiple times despite genuinely strengthening your case, or if your circumstances are otherwise complex.